

Sample Assignment Using the WEA: A Student Edition of “A Contract”

Morgan Kelly’s edition of “A Contract” by Onoto Watanna was conceived in the context of an upper-division literary studies class called [“Americans All”: African, Native, and Asian American Literature, 1865-1914](#) taught in the spring of 2024 at the [College of Charleston](#), a mid-sized public, comprehensive university in Charleston, South Carolina, US. The class took a historicized, comparative approach to writing from three marginalized groups during a transformative period in US social history, aiming also to elucidate America’s present through understanding diverse literary and cultural legacies.

Students were assigned to read two texts from the [Playing Japanese](#) section of the [Winnifred Eaton Archive](#) (WEA): [“A Contract”](#) and [“Miss Lily and Miss Chrysanthemum.”](#) As an introduction to our class discussion of Winnifred Eaton (Onoto Watanna) and in addition to these texts, students read the [Oxford Bibliographies entry on Winnifred Eaton](#) (penned by Mary Chapman, Sydney Lines, and Heidi Rennert), browsed and discussed in class the WEA [Biographical Timeline](#) of Winnifred Eaton’s life, and were invited to tour the archive on their own.

Morgan Kelly, one of the students, for their final project proposed to create a student edition of “A Contract,” and after discussions of what the project might entail, we agreed to the guidelines reproduced below. For context, students who wish to earn the highest grade in the class must, among other things, successfully propose and complete [a final project of their own design](#). The proposal process includes consultation between the student and instructor. The submitted project is accompanied by [a reflection](#) on the process and completed product.

Below is the assignment sheet that represents the final, agreed-upon specifications for Morgan Kelly’s edition of “A Contract.” We hope this document will suggest various opportunities for students’ editorial engagement with the Winnifred Eaton Archive. Instructors should feel free to make use of this assignment in part or full without attribution and to provide Kelly’s edition of “A Contract” as an example.

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Assignment Guidelines and Specifications

Student Edition of Onoto Watanna's (Winnifred Eaton's) "A Contract"

Project as Described in Morgan Kelly’s Proposal

I’d like to create a student edition of Onoto Watanna’s (Winnifred Eaton’s) short story “A Contract.” I find her adoption of a Japanese persona, despite her having no connections to the culture, incredibly interesting. As part of the edition, I would include an introduction, footnotes and images throughout the actual text and context for the story, such as foreign relations at the time. I think it could be interesting in the context section to look at how the Chinese and the Japanese were viewed in America at the time. I can’t remember which author wrote about the Japanese being considered a “fine race,” while the Chinese are

considered dirty and a threat to the American workforce. I think it could be really interesting to view Onoto Watanna's texts through this lens.

I would include footnotes for words that are common in Japanese culture (such as "San" or "Obi") or list them in an appendix. In the context section, I would likely discuss Chinese Exclusion in both America and Canada and detail the impact it had on Winnifred Eaton and her family. The introduction would provide a brief overview of Winnifred Eaton/Onoto Watanna's career, discussing notable works and common themes throughout her stories.

Edition Project Deliverables

- **Introduction** (900-1200 words), which should include
 - brief biographical treatment of Winnifred Eaton, including literary output and recurring themes
 - essential context, given the audience (which you will need to define), but which should include the relative stature in North America of Japanese versus Chinese people at the time of the story's publication
- **Reading Text of "A Contract,"** with a design and layout appropriate for a reading text
- **Footnotes or Other Textual Apparatus**
Whether to employ footnotes, endnotes, glossary, and/or appendices is for you to decide as editor. What should be included in any apparatus should be guided by your understanding of gaps in the audience's knowledge, but this will likely include:
 - definitions of unfamiliar terms
 - explanations of unfamiliar contexts
- **Images:** include some or all of the images from the original periodical text, using editorial judgment for selection and making design decisions about formatting

Final Project Reflection

See instructions [here](#).

Specifications for Assessment

1. For the project to be assessed as completed, the project's deliverables should match all the characteristics outlined above.
2. Additionally, a [Final Project Reflection](#) that meets all its specifications must be submitted.